

Tab 1

CHAPTER 1: Short-Term Cash Flow & Liquidity Triage (Months 0–6)

Status: UNLOCKED & ACTIVE

Primary Quest: Eliminate credit card interest traps, build your \$11,300 cash shield, and neutralize monthly budget leaks before the March ESPP purchase date.

Main Quests & Action Items

- **Quest 1: Defeat High-Interest Liabilities (Deadline: Oct 2)**
 - Transfer \$3,824.35 from BofA Savings (\$5,836.22 balance) via autopay to clear the Chase statement balance in full and avoid 20%+ interest.
 - Lock the physical Chase credit card in the app and remove it from Apple Pay, Amazon, and DoorDash to freeze the unbilled \$1,554.49 balance.
- **Quest 2: Execute the Dead-Weight Cash Sweep**
 - Sweep the remaining \$2,011.87 sitting in 0%-yield BofA Savings straight into your high-yield Ally HYSA.
 - Instantly raise your Ally HYSA balance from \$6,236.14 to \$8,247.01, closing 40% of your remaining emergency gap on Day 1.
- **Quest 3: Establish the \$500 Discretionary Inventory Cap**
 - Isolate \$500 on a separate debit card split strictly into \$250 dining out, \$150 shopping, and \$100 entertainment.
 - Track hidden baseline overhead (\$644.88 for gas, parking, haircuts) to keep total Needs bounded at \$4,435.38.
- **Quest 4: Automate the Biweekly Yield Sweep**
 - Schedule auto-transfers of \$727.44 into Ally HYSA every payday (\$1,454.89 monthly total surplus) out of your \$6,823.60 net income.
 - Maintain your automated \$433.33 monthly Roth IRA transfer to preserve tax-free retirement growth.

Boss Battle & Chapter 2 Unlock Requirements

To complete **Chapter 1** and unlock **Chapter 2: Equity Monetization & Floating Strategy**, you must achieve all three conditions:

1. **Zero Interest Incurred:** Chase statement balance cleared on October 2nd.
2. **Emergency Shield Maxed:** Ally HYSA hits the **\$11,300.00** threshold (projected mid-January 2027).
3. **Discretionary Lock:** 90 consecutive days without exceeding the \$500 monthly "Wants" cap.

CHAPTER 2: Short-to-Mid-Term Equity Monetization & Floating Strategy (Months 6–12)

Status: *LOCKED (Unlocks upon Chapter 1 Boss Defeat)*

Primary Quest: Monetize company stock immediately upon vesting, cover tax true-up liabilities, and build the "Rolling Cash Float" inside your Ally HYSA to prepare for aggressive pre-tax retirement deferrals.

Main Quests & Action Items

- **Quest 1: Execute the RSU First-Tranche Liquidation (41-Day Countdown)**
 - Monetize your first \$5,000 quarterly tranche of your \$80,000 RSU grant immediately upon vesting (in ~41 days).
 - Reserve ~2%–5% of gross RSU proceeds in cash to cover the federal supplemental tax true-up gap (22% standard withholding vs. your 24% actual marginal rate).
 - Sweep the net cash proceeds straight into your Ally HYSA rather than absorbing them into BofA checking.
- **Quest 2: Execute the March 1st ESPP Flip**
 - Sell 100% of your accumulated ESPP shares immediately on the March 1, 2027 purchase date to eliminate single-stock employer concentration risk.
 - Realize the \$6,041.70 in accumulated payroll deductions (10 pay periods at \$604.17/paycheck) plus the discounted purchase upside.
 - Direct the full \$6,000+ lump sum into your Ally HYSA liquidity vault.
- **Quest 3: Initialize the "Rolling Cash Float" System**
 - Combine your \$11,300 emergency fund shield with the ~\$6,000+ ESPP proceeds and RSU vests to build a liquid cash reserve of \$17,000+ in Ally HYSA.
 - Establish a designated \$500/month automatic transfer protocol from Ally HYSA to BofA checking to act as a income-replacement buffer when pre-tax 401(k) contributions are increased in Chapter 3.

Boss Battle & Chapter 3 Unlock Requirements

To complete **Chapter 2** and unlock **Chapter 3: Mid-Term Tax-Advantaged Optimization**, you must achieve all three conditions:

1. **Zero Single-Stock Holding:** 100% of vested RSUs and March 1st ESPP shares liquidated within 48 hours of acquisition.
2. **Tax Liability Shielded:** True-up tax reserve set aside in Ally HYSA for the 24% Federal / 9.3% CA marginal bracket gap.
3. **Liquidity Vault Reached:** Total Ally HYSA balance reaches **\$17,000+** from combined cash sweeps and equity sales.

CHAPTER 3: Mid-Term Tax-Advantaged Optimization (Years 1–3)

Status: LOCKED (Unlocks upon Chapter 2 Boss Defeat)

Primary Quest: Pivot from raw liquidity hoarding to aggressive tax shielding by maximizing your pre-tax and triple-tax-advantaged retirement accounts to combat your ~33.3% marginal tax rate.

Main Quests & Action Items

- **Quest 1: Maximize Pre-Tax 401(k) Shielding**
 - Ramp your 401(k) contribution rate from the triage-level 2% up to 15% immediately after your Chapter 2 cash float is established.
 - At your ~\$145,000 base salary, a 15% contribution rate will defer roughly \$21,750 per year, bringing you close to the 2026 IRS employee maximum of \$24,500. This single move will mathematically save you over \$7,000 annually in federal and state income taxes.
- **Quest 2: Reactivate & Maximize the HSA**
 - Turn your biweekly HSA payroll deduction back on to capture triple-tax-advantaged wealth (tax-free in, tax-free growth, tax-free out for medical).
 - Set your contribution to max out the 2026 IRS single limit of \$4,400 per year (roughly \$169.23 per biweekly paycheck).
- **Quest 3: Bridge the Cash Flow Gap (The Float Execution)**
 - Cranking your 401(k) to 15% and maxing the HSA will shrink your net take-home pay, making it mathematically impossible to fund your baseline \$4,435.38 Needs and \$500 Wants strictly on payroll.
 - Manually transfer a portion of your ESPP and RSU cash proceeds (currently parked in your Ally HYSA from Chapter 2) into your BofA checking account every month to "float" your living expenses. You are effectively laundering taxable company stock into permanent, tax-protected wealth.
 - Continue your automated \$433.33 monthly Roth IRA transfers to maintain tax-free growth diversification.

Boss Battle & Chapter 4 Unlock Requirements

To complete **Chapter 3** and unlock **Chapter 4: Asset Allocation & Investment Growth**, you must achieve all three conditions:

1. **Tax Shield Optimized:** 401(k) deferral raised to a minimum of 15% pre-tax.
2. **Triple-Tax Vault Capped:** HSA contributions on track to hit the \$4,400 IRS maximum for the year.
3. **Float Stability Reached:** Successfully execute 3 consecutive months of transferring HYSA equity proceeds to cover your monthly checking account deficit without swiping the locked Chase card.

CHAPTER 4: Mid-to-Long-Term Asset Allocation & Investment Growth (Years 3–5)

Status: **LOCKED** (Unlocks upon Chapter 3 Boss Defeat)

Primary Quest: Construct a low-cost, broad-market index core, systematically rebalance away from employer single-stock concentration, and automate net surplus compounding across taxable accounts.

Main Quests & Action Items

- **Quest 1: Construct a Broad-Market Index Core**
 - Direct all non-retirement brokerage capital (such as your Fidelity Investment account) into broad-market index funds (e.g., total stock market or S&P 500 index funds) to capture market-matching returns with ultra-low expense ratios.
 - Eliminate stock picking or speculative assets to maintain risk-adjusted portfolio growth and avoid single-asset drawdown risks.
- **Quest 2: Systematize Ongoing Employer Equity Rebalancing**
 - Enforce an automated rule to liquidate 100% of all future ESPP purchases and quarterly RSU vesting tranches within 48 hours of release.
 - Immediately sweep liquidated equity proceeds into broad-market index funds or use them to sustain your 15% pre-tax 401(k) and maxed HSA deferrals.
- **Quest 3: Automate Surplus Wealth Compounding**
 - Once your Ally HYSA rolling float remains fully stabilized at target levels (\$17,000+), establish automated monthly sweeps of any remaining cash surpluses straight into your taxable brokerage account.
 - Verify that dividend reinvestment (DRIP) is enabled across all accounts (401(k), Roth IRA, HSA, and taxable brokerage) to maximize passive compounding.

Boss Battle & Chapter 5 Unlock Requirements

To complete **Chapter 4** and unlock **Chapter 5: Long-Term Financial Independence & Debt Elimination**, you must achieve all three conditions:

1. **Employer Concentration Shielded:** Employer single-stock equity represents less than 5% of your total net worth at any given time.
2. **Index Core Established:** Taxable brokerage capital fully invested in broad-market index funds with automatic dividend reinvestment active.
3. **Surplus Engine Automated:** Automated monthly sweeps routing all net cash surpluses directly into investment vehicles.

CHAPTER 5: Long-Term Financial Independence & Debt Elimination (Years 5+)

Status: LOCKED (Unlocks upon Chapter 4 Boss Defeat)

Primary Quest: Eliminate remaining non-mortgage liabilities, construct a tax-optimized multi-bucket drawdown engine, and scale your net worth toward full financial independence.

Main Quests & Action Items

- **Quest 1: Accelerated Debt Eradication**
 - Once your tax-advantaged accounts (401(k), HSA, Roth IRA) are fully maxed out and broad-market taxable brokerage compounding is automated, direct remaining cash flow surpluses to extinguish your remaining car loan balance (\$367/month minimum).
 - Maintain baseline student loan minimums (\$350/month) or execute accelerated payoff depending on interest rates relative to expected broad-market yields.
- **Quest 2: Construct a Tax-Efficient Multi-Bucket Drawdown Engine**
 - Maintain balanced wealth across three primary tax buckets to control your future effective tax rate during retirement:
 - 1. **Pre-Tax Bucket (401(k)):** Reduces high-earning W-2 income now (~33.3% marginal rate) and fills lower tax brackets in retirement.
 2. **Tax-Free Bucket (Roth IRA & HSA):** Provides completely tax-free income in retirement and medical reimbursement space.
 3. **Taxable Bucket (Brokerage):** Acts as a bridge account for early independence before age 59½, taxed at favorable long-term capital gains rates.
- **Quest 3: Scale Savings Rate & Net Worth Expansion**
 - As base salary increases and RSU vests refresh beyond your current \$145,000 base and \$80,000 RSU grant, commit at least 50% of all future salary raises directly to investment compounding.
 - Target a long-term savings rate of 35%–45%+ of gross income to accelerate your financial independence timeline.

Boss Battle & Final Victory Conditions (Game Clear)

To complete **Chapter 5** and achieve **Full Financial Independence**, you must satisfy all three core parameters:

1. **Consumer Debt Free:** Car loan and high-interest liabilities completely cleared.
2. **Three-Bucket Diversification:** Wealth distributed across Taxable Brokerage, Pre-Tax 401(k), and Tax-Free Roth/HSA accounts.

3. **Financial Independence Threshold:** Investment net worth reaches 25x your annual essential baseline living costs, enabling a sustainable 4% annual withdrawal rate.

Tab 2

Base Income & Tax Brackets

1. What is your exact gross pay per paycheck before any tax or payroll deductions are taken?
2. How frequently are you paid by your employer throughout the calendar year?
3. What is your current tax filing status for federal and state tax purposes?
4. In which state do you currently reside for income tax purposes?
5. What is the exact dollar amount or percentage of your pre-tax deductions per paycheck?
6. What is the total estimated tax currently withheld from each paycheck across federal, state, and FICA taxes combined?

Equity Vesting Rules

1. According to your "Personal Finance" file, what is the exact vesting frequency and percentage schedule for your active RSU grants?
2. What is the specific purchase discount percentage on your ESPP, and does the plan include a lookback provision?
3. What default supplemental tax withholding rate does your employer apply to your equity vests for federal and state taxes?
4. Are your company equity holdings subject to strict quarterly trading blackout windows, or do you have a 10b5-1 plan configured for automatic sell-on-vest liquidation?

Fixed & Discretionary Expenses

1. What is your exact monthly housing expense, including rent, mortgage payments, property taxes, and home insurance?
2. What are the total monthly minimum required payments for all non-mortgage debt obligations, such as auto loans, student loans, and personal loans?
3. How much do you spend on average each month for utility bills, including electricity, water, gas, internet, and trash services?
4. What is your estimated monthly baseline expenditure for groceries and essential household supplies?
5. What are your recurring monthly out-of-pocket costs for health, dental, vision, life, and disability insurance premiums?
6. How much do you spend monthly on transportation costs, including fuel, public transit, parking, tolls, and routine vehicle maintenance?
7. What is the total combined monthly cost of all active subscription services, memberships, and recurring digital plans?
8. What is your target monthly cap or average spending on discretionary lifestyle categories, such as dining out, shopping, hobbies, and entertainment?

Liquid Account Balances

1. What is the current total available balance across all your active checking accounts used for daily expenses?
2. What is the exact current balance and annual percentage yield (APY) of your primary high-yield savings or dedicated emergency fund accounts?
3. What is your specific target dollar amount for a fully funded emergency reserve based on your baseline monthly survival costs?
4. What is the total balance of any additional liquid cash held in traditional savings accounts or short-term cash equivalents?

Liability Metrics

1. What are the total outstanding balances and most recent statement balances across all your active credit card accounts?
2. What is the exact annual percentage rate (APR) charged on each of your credit card balances?
3. What is the total required minimum monthly payment across all of your revolving credit card debts?
4. What are the remaining principal balances, interest rates, and required minimum monthly payments for any active installment loans, such as auto or personal loans?
5. What are the total balances, interest rates, and required monthly payments for all outstanding federal or private student loans?

Employer Match & Retirement Progress

1. What are the specific terms of your employer's 401(k) or 403(b) match, including the match percentage, maximum dollar or percentage cap, and required employee deferral rate?
2. What are your current year-to-date contribution totals and total existing account balances across all pre-tax and Roth retirement accounts?
3. Are you currently enrolled in a qualifying High Deductible Health Plan (HDHP) for HSA eligibility, and do your income levels permit direct Roth IRA contributions or require alternative strategies?